



THE OVERFLOW

010 / 15 AUG 2010 / BITCOIN / RARE

WE NEED A FIX ASAP.

A glass block splits open and a flood of golden coins pours into the room. Two people work at a control station as the impossible balance climbs. Beyond them, a blue line of blocks continues while a red branch breaks apart. This is a picture of a network repairing its history, not a room or machine that existed.

On 15 August 2010, Jeff Garzik noticed something strange in Bitcoin block 74,638. A transaction had two outputs of more than 92 billion BTC each. Added together, their values overflowed the software's arithmetic check and slipped past a limit that should have rejected them. The result was roughly 184.47 billion invalid bitcoins in that branch of the chain.

The response was urgent and collective. A forum post called for a fix as soon as possible. Gavin Andresen offered an early patch, other participants examined the failure, and Satoshi worked on the correction. Version 0.3.10 patched the overflow bug that same day. The corrected chain overtook the bad branch; those impossible coins are not part of Bitcoin's accepted history.

The pictured workers are anonymous and imagined, rather than portraits of the people who found and fixed the flaw. Their shared console stands for the public effort. The coin torrent gives an invisible arithmetic error physical scale. One conspicuous coin carries a different mark: a deliberate glimpse of a later card, hidden in a scene set before that currency existed.

HIDDEN IN THE ART

01 THE DAMAGED BLOCK

The metal cradle is stamped "74,638," the height of the block in which the overflow was spotted. The glass container is symbolic.

02 AN IMPOSSIBLE BALANCE

"184.47B" on the amber counter rounds the invalid quantity. It is not a claim about Bitcoin's valid supply.

03 THE EMERGENCY PATCH

"0.3.10" glows blue on the console. Satoshi's release post identifies this version as the overflow patch.

04 ONE WRONG COIN

A single larger Dogecoin-marked coin hides among the Bitcoin cascade. It is an intentional forward reference to Birth of Doge, not a historical object in 2010.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Jeff Garzik's [original block report](#) records height 74,638 and the two enormous outputs. The [emergency discussion](#) contains the source phrase "We need a fix asap," the collaborative patch discussion and Satoshi's preliminary checks. Satoshi's [version 0.3.10 announcement](#) records the patch and later notes that the good chain overtook the bad one. The hall, glass cube, coins, characters and console are interpretive illustration. The Dogecoin coin is a fictional crossover to another LORE card.